

Study Questions: Systems — What Makes a Circle a Circle

1. Describe the **Markov blanket** of your crochet circle (or one you can imagine). What separates the "inside" of the group from the "outside"? Is the boundary sharp or fuzzy?
2. List three examples of **internal states** that your circle has accumulated over time. Why would these be invisible or inaccessible to a first-time visitor?
3. A member brings a new stitch technique they found on YouTube to the circle meeting. Trace this information's path from **external state** through the **blanket states** and into the **internal states** of the group.
4. What role does the **meeting space** play as a blanket state? How would moving from a coffee shop to a member's living room change the dynamics of the system?
5. Compare a crochet circle that has met weekly for five years with one that has just formed this month. How do their internal states differ? What about their Markov blankets?
6. When a founding member of the circle moves away, what happens to the **internal states** they carried? How does the circle reorganize to maintain its identity?
7. Think about **shared materials** — communal pattern books, spare hooks, a shared yarn stash for newcomers. Are these internal states, external states, or blanket states? Justify your classification.
8. A crochet circle decides to host a booth at a local craft fair. Analyze this action in terms of **active states** — how is the circle's inside influencing its outside?
9. What are the **sensory states** through which external information enters your circle? Consider news about yarn sales, new pattern trends, community events.
10. Two crochet circles in the same town sometimes share members who attend both. How does this overlap affect each circle's Markov blanket? Are the circles one system or two?

11. Consider a circle where all communication happens online (a virtual crochet group on social media). Does this group have the same kind of Markov blanket as an in-person circle? What is different about its boundaries?
12. A circle's **group norms** (when to offer help, how to welcome newcomers, whether to use patterns or freehand) are internal states. How do these norms form? Can they change, and if so, what drives the change?
13. How does the concept of **self-evidencing** apply to a crochet circle? What actions does the circle take that confirm and maintain its own existence?
14. Think about the **external states** of your circle — the wider crafting community, local yarn shops, online forums. How do these external states constrain what the circle does? Can the circle influence them in return?
15. A newcomer joins the circle for the first time. Describe this event as a change in the system's boundary. What must the circle's blanket states do to accommodate the new member?
16. Consider the **lifecycle** of a crochet circle: formation, growth, maturity, and possible dissolution. At each stage, how does the Markov blanket change? When is it most fragile?
17. Your circle is **nested** within larger systems — the local crafting community, the regional fiber arts world, the global crochet culture. Give an example of information flowing from the largest scale down to your circle's internal states.
18. How does a crochet circle differ from a crochet class? Both involve people crocheting together, but their system structures are different. Compare their Markov blankets, internal states, and persistence over time.
19. If your circle keeps a shared project journal or photo album, how does this artifact relate to the system's internal states? Is it internal state, or does it serve a blanket function by making internal states visible to outsiders?

20. Reflect on what it means for a crochet circle to be **more than the sum of its parts**.

What properties of the circle-as-system cannot be explained by looking at each individual member alone?